

Unit 3 – Section 5: Assessing Competitiveness

Exam Patterns & Trends (2019 – 2025)

Overview of Exam Patterns

Mark Type	Typical Command Words	Frequency	Focus Areas
4 marks	Define / Calculate / Explain	Every Paper	Calculation-based tasks (profit ratios, liquidity, productivity).
8 marks	Assess	Frequent	Financial data interpretation, ratio trends, HR metrics.
12 marks	Discuss	Frequent	Comparison of data sources and performance measures.
20 marks	Evaluate	Every Paper	Balanced judgement on the usefulness of financial and non-financial data.

AO Weighting: AO1 (20%), AO2 (25%), AO3 (25%), AO4 (30%)

Topic Trend Analysis (2019 – 2025)

Topic	Year & Question Reference	Command Words	Trend Summary
Income Statements	2020 Jun Q1a, 2022 Jan Q2a, 2024 Oct Q1	Explain / Evaluate	Frequent in 4–20 mark questions focusing on profit analysis and cost control.
Financial Position (Balance Sheet)	2019 Oct Q3, 2021 Jun Q2b, 2023 Jan Q1b	Explain / Discuss	Appears every 1–2 papers; assesses

Interpretation of Financial Statements	2020 Oct Q2b, 2023 Jun Q3	Assess / Discuss	liquidity, capital structure, and solvency. Linked to trend analysis, external comparisons, and non-financial data integration.
Ratio Analysis	2021 Jan Q3, 2022 Jun Q2c, 2024 Jun Q3	Calculate / Evaluate	Common 8–20 mark focus; profit margins, gearing, liquidity, and ROCE.
Human Resource Data & Ratios	2020 Jun Q1b, 2023 Oct Q1d	Explain / Discuss	Appears regularly as support to competitiveness and efficiency discussions.

Predicted Focus for Jan 2026 Exam

Predicted Topic	Mark	Command Word	Likely Context
Ratio Analysis	20	Evaluate	Evaluate whether ratio analysis provides an accurate reflection of business performance.
Income Statement	12	Discuss	Discuss whether profitability is the best indicator of business success.
Financial Position	8	Assess	Assess the usefulness of a balance sheet for short-term decision-making.
HR Ratios	4	Explain	Explain one benefit of monitoring labour productivity.
Interpretation of	8	Assess	Assess the value of

Accounts

comparing
performance across
different accounting
periods.

Teacher Revision Tips

- Focus on calculation accuracy (ratios and margins) and interpretation in context.
- Reinforce links between finance (Unit 2) and HR performance indicators (Unit 3).
- Use real company data — e.g., Tesco Annual Reports, Greggs financial updates, and airline gearing ratios.
- For evaluation, compare short- vs long-term impacts (profit vs liquidity, cost vs efficiency).
- Encourage students to interpret figures using 'depends on' and 'external influence' reasoning.

Key Takeaways

- Every exam includes at least one question on financial data interpretation.
- Ratio analysis remains the most frequent calculation and evaluation focus.
- Integration with HR and operational data is increasingly common.
- High marks depend on linking quantitative results to qualitative insights.
- Jan 2026 is likely to feature Ratio Analysis (20 marks) and HR Ratios (4 marks).